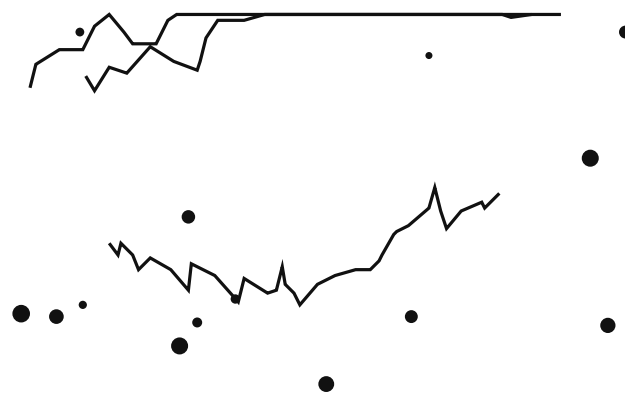


Papier Bleu

No. 49 • January 2019

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No. 49

JANUARY 2019

PROSE POETRY

PAPIER BLEU

No. 49 · January 2019

A monthly magazine of prose poetry by writers from
Uppsala, Stockholm and Lund universities.

Where to find it. Free, at the university library and the
student nations in Uppsala, from the first of the month
while copies last.

Set in Courier Prime. Printed in Uppsala. 50 copies.

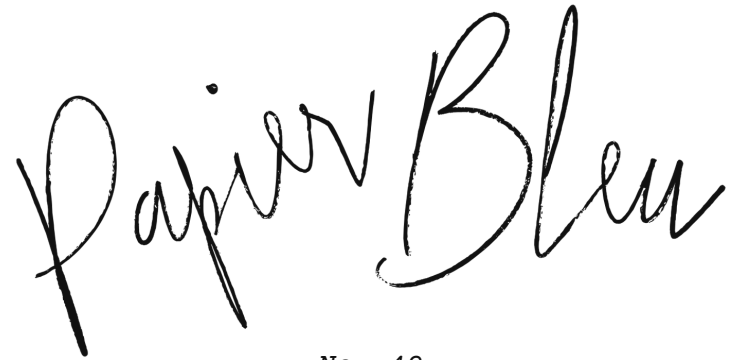
Ingrid U. (Lund Univ.) builds the fire in the sauna every Saturday and sits on the top bench.

Maja A. (Uppsala Univ.) has lived in Uppsala for four winters and counts them.

Freja S. (Lund Univ.) studies in Lund, declares nothing at borders, and is waved through.

Emil B. (Lund Univ.) makes maps, mostly of places he has not been.

Ebba A. (Lund Univ.) skates the bay at dusk and knows the ice by its sounds.



No. 49

JANUARY 2019

Ten writers on the second language

MASTHEAD

Founder & Editor-in-Chief

Kristil Rabideau

Papier Bleu is an independent student magazine. It is not an official publication of Uppsala University, and the views expressed belong to the writers.

Contributors are listed on pages 17 and 18.

CONTRIBUTORS

Tove E. (Uppsala Univ.) studies linguistics in Uppsala and walks the fields past the last bus stop.

Astrid J. (Uppsala Univ.) is a physics student who measures winter in minutes of daylight.

Saga N. (Stockholm Univ.) spends her summers at her grandmother's lake in Dalarna.

Wilma U. (Stockholm Univ.) teaches English to her grandmother and learns Swedish again.

Nils U. (Stockholm Univ.) grew up on subtitled television and is studying law.

ICE, THICKENING

Ebba A. · Lund Univ.

4 cm. Skin of it only. At the edge of the bay, the first night, a pane that sings when a stone skips across it, a long falling whistle like a wire pulled through water. Lie down on the shore and put your ear to it: it ticks.

9 cm. Gray now, clouded with bubbles caught mid-rise like beads of breath. Your boots slide a hand's width and the ice answers underfoot with a low groan. Boys on the far shore, voices flat and thin, a mile away and in your ear.

14 cm. A man walks out with an auger. The drill shrieks and spits a fountain of white shavings and breaks through into black water that smells of rust and cold mud. Somewhere far off the ice cracks like a rifle, one long boom going away across the lake, and nobody looks up.

20 cm. Skates. The blade bites with the sound of tearing silk, your cheeks sting, the wind comes up your sleeves and you go, and the bay is a clear gray floor with the dark shapes of fish turning under your feet.

26 cm. A plowed road. A table out on the ice with a candle in a jar, and hot blackcurrant in paper cups that burn your hand through the wool, clove and sugar steaming into your face.

April. The same bay, black and loose, and no one can say exactly where the road was.

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INTERESTED IN SUBMITTING?

Send works no longer than 500 words, in the form of prose poetry. If you are looking for clarity, the best example is Italo Calvino's *Invisible Cities*, or this issue.

Send your work to rabideaukristil@gmail.com.

Please title your email "Papier Bleu Submission" for easy finding.

LEGEND FOR A MAP WITHOUT ITS MAP

Emil B. · Lund Univ.

The map has been lost. The legend remains, and is read by those who have forgotten where they were going.

- (o) a house where my name was said correctly
- (+) a bench that has heard the whole story
- (~) a river crossed in order to be forgiven
- (x) the place you were sure of
- (=) a bridge between two sentences
- (.) you are here, but not for long

Those who follow the legend arrive, eventually, where all the symbols agree. It is unmarked and very small.

CUSTOMS OF THE SECOND LANGUAGE

Freja S. · Lund Univ.

BORDER OF THE SECOND LANGUAGE. DECLARATION.

Name: (as pronounced here)

Purpose of visit: To be understood. To be misunderstood less.

Length of stay: Until I dream in it.

Anything to declare? One lullaby, in poor repair. Several hundred words I do not need. A joke that does not cross.

Are you carrying food? The word for the soup my grandmother made, packed at the bottom of my chest.

Contact with native speakers? Yes, though briefly, and at a distance.

Signature: _____

The officer will return it in a different hand.

UPPLAND, OCTOBER

Tove E. · Uppsala Univ.

The fields of Uppland in late October lie plowed in dark brown rows that smell of cellar and cold iron and run straight to a line of spruce, and over the spruce is a sky the color of dishwater with one white hole in it where the sun is, or was. Cranes stand in the stubble by the hundred, creaking like a gate in wind, a delegation waiting to be received. Every farm has a barn, and every barn is that red, the red of dried blood or of the paint they still make from the old copper mine at Falun, thick and slightly chalky when you rub it, and the paint is why the whole country looks as if it had been told to stand up straight for a photograph. Beside one field, behind a wire fence and a plastic ribbon snapping in the wind, a runestone eleven hundred years old says that a man named Ulf raised it in memory of his brother, and the farmer's cows lean on it to scratch. I know the nouns. Åker, field. Ladugård, barn. Sten, stone. I do not yet have the verbs. Nothing in this country is seen doing anything, only standing there being exactly what it is, and I am told that is the whole language.

FOUR HOURS OF DAYLIGHT

Astrid J. · Uppsala Univ.

In January the sun climbs out at a quarter to nine like a guest who knows nobody at the funeral, stands around the south of the sky with its hands in its pockets, and leaves at three, and in between I have bicycled down Kungsgatan on studded tires that sound like bacon frying, the cold squeaking in my nostrils and freezing the hairs, and bought a cinnamon bun from the bakery by the bridge, warm as a hand, cardamom and sugar crunching in the teeth, and stood on the bridge eating it, and the river Fyris has frozen only at the edges, the middle black and moving, forty ducks on the ice all facing the same direction as if the ice had a bus coming, and I think in physics but I dream in my mother's Swedish, which is worse, it is all arguments, and at fifteen past three it is dark and every window on the street has a candle in it, even the windows of people who say they don't, a whole street of small flames like a ship going by, and I stand in the cold holding my bicycle with the handlebar burning through my mitten, thinking that this is the one thing I would tell my mother, in English, if she asked what the winter is like: that everyone lights one.

FOUR WINTERS

Maja A. · Uppsala Univ.

The first winter, I woke in a room with a window and a lamp and did not know the words for either.

The second winter, I woke in a rum with a fönster and a lampa, and knew those. I did not yet know the word for how long the night was.

The third winter, I vaknade in a rum with a fönster, och the natt was lång, och outside it snöade, och I thought, in no language at all, hem.

The fourth winter, jag vaknade i mitt rum, vid mitt fönster, och nattens ljus var snö, och jag tänkte inte alls. Det var tyst. Det var, tror jag, hemma.

SATURDAY, BASTU

Ingrid U. · Lund Univ.

On Saturday the whole house walks down to the lake
and the sauna, a hut tarred black, a stove of river
stones, birch smoke caught in the rafters, the
door swollen with damp and shouldered open. You
sit where you are told. The air on the lowest bench
is only warm.

FIRST BENCH

planks wet and cool under the thighs
a drip somewhere, ankles in shade

SECOND BENCH

the hair on your arms stands up
smoke, birch, a little tar

THIRD BENCH

one ladle on the stones: a sheet
torn in half, and then the heat
laid flat on the crown of your head

TOP BENCH

ears ringing, eyelids hot as coins,
sweat running into the corners
of the mouth. Salt.

Then the door, and the dock, and the lake, a cold
so total it has no temperature. The whole body
shouts once, without a sound, and goes quiet and
pink and new. Snow melts on your shoulders in the
dark, and overhead are the sparks the old women say
got out of the stove.

FARMOR'S LAKE

Saga N. · Stockholm Univ.

My grandmother's lake is the color of tea left in
the pot, warm on top and cold two feet down where
your toes begin to have opinions. The dock boards
are silver and splintery and in July hot enough to
dance on. The cabin sits above it on stones she and
my grandfather carried up in 1961, which she
mentions about as often as the weather, and inside
it smells of woodsmoke and wet dog and coffee
boiled twice. Behind the cabin is the outhouse
with a heart cut in the door, which I thought was
romantic until I was eleven. In the woods the
lingonberries lie like spilled beads, sour enough
to make your ears ring, and the mosquitoes are of a
size and civility that suggest they were
introduced to us, and when I come in with my mouth
stained red she says something in the dialect of
her valley, which I understand the way you
understand a radio in the next room, all rhythm and
no words: a question, then the answer to it, then a
sound that means the coffee is ready. I answer in
Swedish. She answers in what I am told is also
Swedish. We have had this conversation for twenty
years and agreed on everything.

PHRASEBOOK FOR A COUNTRY ALMOST LEARNED

Wilma U. · Stockholm Univ.

Useful expressions. Read the left-hand column aloud; keep the right to yourself.

SAY Excuse me, where is the station?

MEAN Where did you go?

SAY Thank you, no, I'm fine.

MEAN I am not fine; ask again.

SAY What a nice day!

MEAN I have run out of other subjects.

SAY I'm sorry, I don't understand.

MEAN I understand, and wish I did not.

SAY Do you live here?

MEAN Will you let me?

SAY See you soon.

MEAN The weather will decide.

The country is small and has no border. You are in it as soon as you stop translating, and out of it the moment you notice.

SUBTITLES

Nils U. · Stockholm Univ.

We learned English from television, in the blue light that moved on the ceiling after bedtime, because in Sweden they do not dub, they let the Americans talk and put our language along the bottom of the screen in small white letters, a ticker of what they really meant. So at eight I knew that *Freeze!* was *Stanna!* and that *honey* could be a word for a wife or for a person you were about to shoot. On Friday nights the whole building went quiet for the one about the Texas oil family, the smell of Mrs. Lindqvist's cardamom buns coming through the wall, and through the wall too you could hear her reading the subtitles aloud a half second ahead of the actors, a prophet of the plot. We were all fluent in a language none of us had been taught, built entirely of what the translator had room for. A man could say *I love you* three different ways with the same mouth and the subtitle had space for one. I still hear it. When I finally went to London I opened my mouth in a shop and a perfect American sentence came out, with its small white letters running underneath, and the girl at the till looked at the bottom of my face.